

Federico Fellini's *La Strada* is released (and later wins the first Oscar for best foreign film); **François Truffaut** describes his auteur theory.



1954

Satyajit Ray's low-budget *Pathar Panchali*, a coming-of-age story, is the first **Indian movie** to win international acclaim.



1955

Hollywood **drops racial epithets** from movies, and allows some references to drugs, abortion, and prostitution.



1956

Alfred Hitchcock's psychological thriller *Vertigo* is released. Hitchcock **is hailed** by French critics as **a true auteur**.



1958

1954



Toho studios in Japan releases the first of the **Godzilla monster movies**. Kurosawa redefines the Western with *Seven Samurai*.

1956



The **science-fiction classics** *Forbidden Planet* and *Invasion of the Body Snatchers* are released.

1957



Ingmar Bergman releases *The Seventh Seal* and *Wild Strawberries*, dealing with his trademark themes of life and death.

1959



Truffaut's debut movie, *The 400 Blows*, marks a high point in the **French New Wave**, dealing realistically with modern society.

young film critics from the magazine *Cahiers du Cinéma* expounded a whole new way of looking at movies. To them, movies deserved respect and intellectual scrutiny. Their studious gaze examined not only "serious" directors such as Ingmar Bergman, but also the populist brilliance of Alfred Hitchcock. The best directors, they argued, filled their work with personal obsessions and visual signatures—what we saw on screen was "authored" by a director just as a novel is by its writer. This was the auteur theory, and for decades it would shape perceptions of movies and their makers.

High ambition

Fittingly, this was the decade in which Hitchcock made what is now the most highly regarded of all his



If it's a good movie, the sound could go off and the audience would still have a perfectly clear idea of what was going on.

Alfred Hitchcock



movies. Some years before, he had been eager to adapt a novel by French crime writers Pierre Boileau and Thomas Narcejac. On that occasion he was beaten to it by

Henri-Georges Clouzot, with whom he enjoyed a friendly rivalry, and who turned the book into the supremely creepy *Les Diaboliques* (1955). Hitchcock made sure he secured the movie rights to what Boileau and Narcejac wrote next—and the result was the intense psychological thriller *Vertigo* (1958), a tale of memory, lust, and loss that now frequently tops the lists of the greatest movies ever made.

In 1959, a movie was made by one of those young French critics responsible for the auteur theory. His name was François Truffaut, and the movie, a portrait of a rough Parisian kid, was *The 400 Blows*. Influenced by Orson Welles but possessed of an energy all of its own, it marked the end of an extraordinary cinematic decade, and the start of a new era. ■